

How did Manchester City Council's expenditure change between Q4 2024 - Q1 2025?

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Tracking how a city council spends its money might not sound like an existing activity, but it is surprisingly revealing. Manchester City Council handles millions of pounds across dozens of services. **If the citizens do not keep an eye on it, no one else will.**

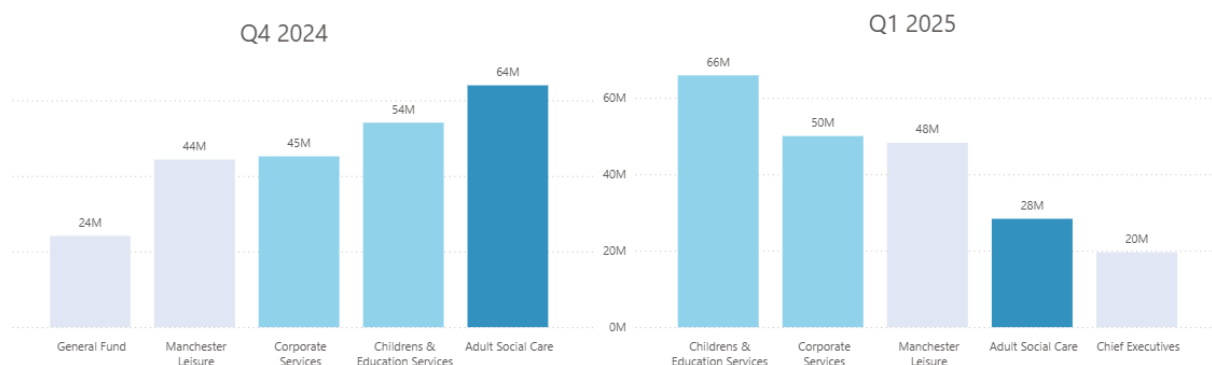
In line with the Government's requirement that local authorities publish details of their expenditure in excess of £500, Manchester City Council publishes this dataset on a monthly basis (Manchester City Council, no date-a). This report will focus on the changes in expenditure and financial distributions for Q4 2024-Q1 2025, as comparing one quarter to the next shows whether money is being used wisely.

TOTAL NET EXPENDITURE

Qtr 1	307.22M ^{-5.51%}
Qtr 4	325.15M

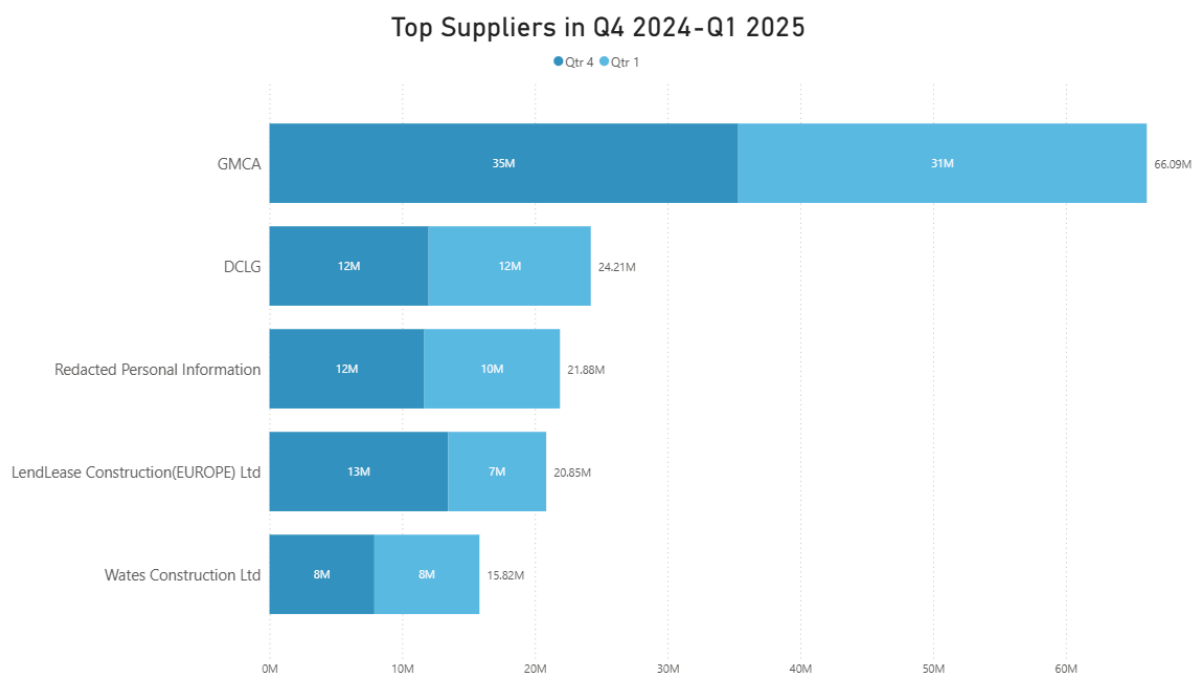
Overall Net Expenditure dropped in Q1 2025. A decrease of 5.51% seems like a small change, but it actually signifies that approximately 17.93M pounds were saved for future expenses. It's a win!

But what has changed in the financial structure? Let's look at the service areas with the highest expenses. In Q4 2024, Adult Social Care received around 64M pounds from the Council, while in Q1 2025 the amount suddenly dropped to 28M. Even so the list of top service areas stayed the same with Corporate Services and Children & Education Services remaining in the top 3.



After seeing such high expenses, a natural question arises - **who** received all this money and **for what**?

Five suppliers with highest net expenditure in Q4 2024 - Q1 2025 feature GMCA - the ten Greater Manchester councils and Mayor working to improve the city-region (Greater Manchester Combined Authority, no date), DCLG - the department focused on fixing the foundations of an affordable home to handing power back to communities and rebuilding local governments (Ministry of Housing, Communities and Local Government, no date), LendLease Construction - a corporation that provides end-to-end capability across all aspects of real estate (Lendlease, no date), and Wates Construction - a building and property maintenance company (Wates, no date).



Overall, the spending pattern suggests that Manchester City Council is focused on housing and construction the most. Interestingly, the chart once again shows that expenses did not increase in Q1 2025. For each of the selected suppliers, the net expenditure either remained on the same level or decreased slightly compared to Q4 2024.

The chart of top suppliers also features Redacted Personal Information, meaning the transaction was made not to a company but to an individual. Their details were anonymised to avoid sharing personal information (Manchester City Council, no date-b).

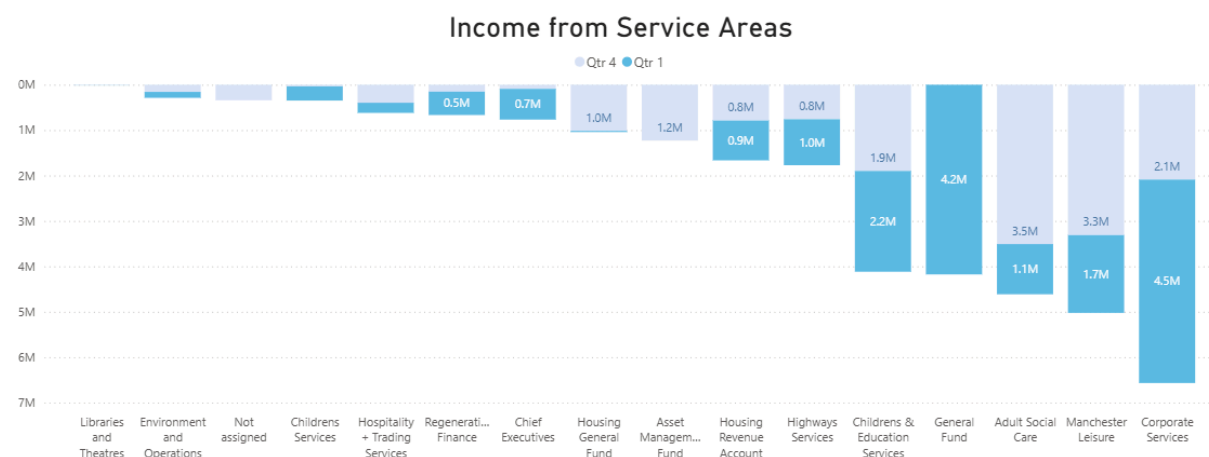
At first glance, the transactions to individuals do not seem unusual in their purpose and amounts. Foster Payments dominate both by Net Expenditure and transactions count, even with a slight drop in Q1 2025. On the other hand, Voluntary Organisations' third parties show a growing reliance on Manchester City Council's support, as expenses slightly increased compared to Q4 2024.

Common Purposes of Transactions to Individuals

Year	2024		2025		Total	
Quarter	Qtr 4		Qtr 1			
Expenses type	Net Expenditure	Number of Transactions	Net Expenditure	Number of Transactions	Net Expenditure	Number of Transactions
Foster Payments	5,575,504.36	5008	4,735,841.60	4313	10,311,345.96	9321
Third party payments relating to Voluntary Organisations	1,269,374.84	728	1,889,797.77	1096	3,159,172.61	1824
Adult Placements	592,323.94	422	534,104.05	379	1,126,427.99	801
Supported Accommodation	248,678.16	165	184,191.68	123	432,869.84	288
Professional fees	578,648.50	121	600,244.76	120	1,178,893.26	241
Payments to Sub-Contractors	148,933.45	128	140,169.28	112	289,102.73	240
Counsel Costs	104,350.41	88	171,688.86	117	276,039.27	205
Ind Budget Payment	64,685.00	86	88,870.00	118	153,555.00	204
Childrens Allowances	102,688.00	153	2,802.00	7	105,490.00	160
Residential Care Homes Payments	1,255,586.54	147	203,386.50	9	1,458,973.04	156

Most of the expenses types show a decrease in numbers and amounts of payments, though a few anomalies stand out. Professional fees went from 578 to 600 thousand pounds, suggesting some fees became higher starting from 2025. Additionally, Residential Care Homes payments in Q1 2025 rose to twice as much as in Q4 2024 in amount, while the number of transactions became quite small. Could be explained by the start of the year - renewing placements and reassessing needs are needed.

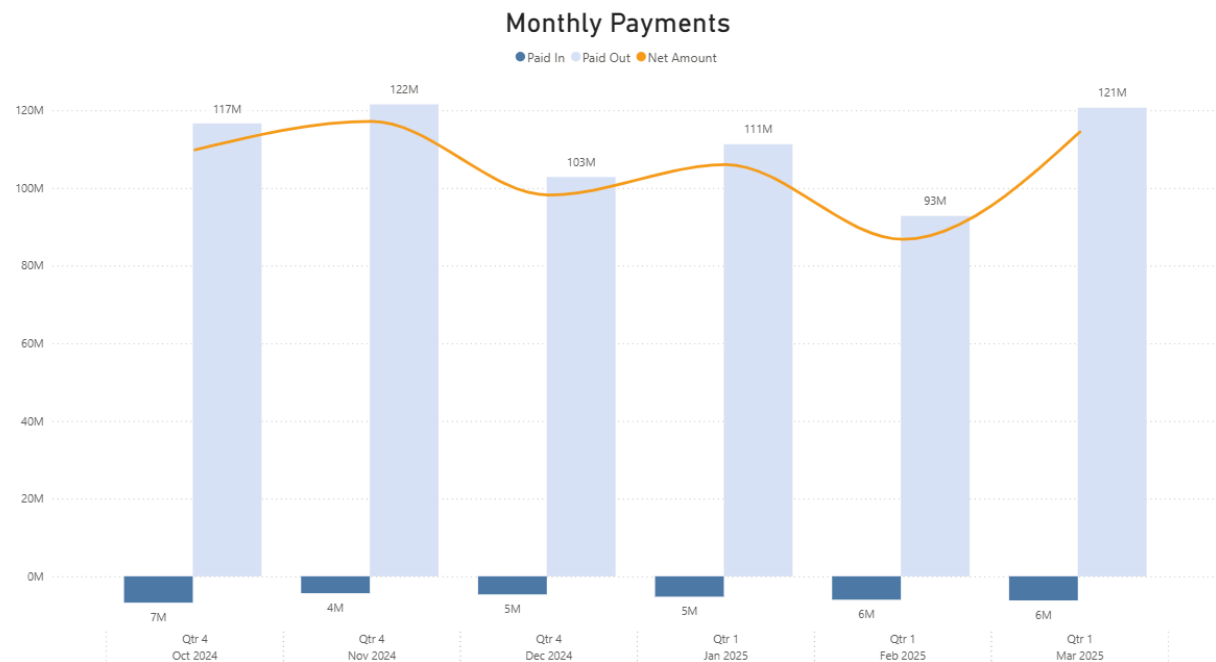
Enough of the expenses. Let's focus on how much money the Manchester City Council received, why and where from. Since the original data is on expenditures only, the income here refers to refunds or accounting corrections.



The income from Corporate Services rose to twice as much as in Q4 2024, affected by a 2M pounds refund from MLP Law Limited for works associated with land and buildings. Another anomaly can be seen in the General Fund - from no income in Q4 2024 to 4.2M pounds in Q1 2025. According to the records, Manchester City Council pays 4M pounds to GMCA monthly. But in March the transaction was processed much later than usual and amounted to

4.2M pounds, suggesting an accounting error that led to refund and possibly a recalculation in Q2 2025.

To complete the review of Q4 2024-Q1 2025 changes, it is also useful to look at the financial statistics by month. Comparisons reveal that October and January had similar expenditure levels, while December and February showed a slight decrease. The average expenses remain stable within the 90-125M range.



Council's returns vary around 5-6M pounds, so it barely affects the net expenditure.

The analysis of Manchester City Council's distribution of finances in Q4 2024-Q1 2025 indicates overall stable expenditure with minor monthly fluctuations. Although total payments slightly decreased in Q1 2025, the distribution of expenses noticeably changed across service areas (drop in Adult Social Care) and individual suppliers (increase in Residential Care Homes). So, while the overall expenditure remained consistent, the priorities and distribution patterns shifted from Q4 2024 to Q1 2025.

CRITICAL REFLECTION

1. Methodology: How did you select and prepare the data? How did you refine your research question?

Analysing Manchester City Council's expenses was not my first choice. Even though I wanted to focus on financial aspects, the initial ideas related to military or small businesses. However, the data for these topics was either unavailable or inconsistent and too mixed. At that point, researching governmental expenses seemed like an only option.

The data was found on data.gov.uk, where Manchester City Council publishes monthly expenditure in line with data transparency regulations (Manchester City Council, no date-a), meaning the data can be trusted. I merged multiple monthly datasets into one, and reviewing it showed that the data is already clean, with no visible anomalies or missing values. So the data cleaning process included only removing columns unrelated to my research and creating new ones to help my analysis.

However, reviewing monthly or quarterly numbers alone is not enough. The readers do not know if the provided amounts spent on service areas and suppliers are high or low, they will only understand it in comparison. So instead of just analysing Q1 2025 (the latest available data), I decided to show how expenditure changed across a period of time - from Q4 2024 to Q1 2025. That is how I got the final research question - How did Manchester City Council's expenditure changed between Q4 2024 - Q1 2025?

2. Use of generative AI: How did you use generative AI in the assessment and how did it improve your data story?

Then the data analysis process started with a bit of support from Generative AI. It helped me format the references correctly, as it was my first time using Harvard style. Yet even such a simple task was done with a few errors, so I reviewed and fixed the references format using Cite Them Right Online (Pears and Shields, 2023).

Also, AI greatly helped me resolve a few problems with visualizations. For example, although the dates were correctly formatted, PowerBI grouped Q4 2024 and Q1 2025 to the same year and showed incorrect trends. Generative AI was used to find the issue and explain how to fix it step-by-step - something that can not always be found by internet search or understood by myself.

As part of completing my research, I used Generative AI to find inconsistencies in my data story. It showed me whether I had misinterpretations in my data and advised how to make my story more consistent. Not all corrections were implemented, but it was important to understand what weak points my research has.

Overall, I used Generative AI like a supporting tool rather than a shortcut to a completed research.

3. What did you do well and what could you improve in your story and visualisations?

One of the main strengths of my data story is its clarity. Comparing Q4 2024 with Q1 2025 provides context for large expenditure amounts that would be much more difficult for a general reader to understand if it was focused on a single month or quarter. The story logically goes from overall expenses to distributions by service areas, suppliers and transaction types, explaining reasons and possible future effects. This makes the analysis understandable to any reader.

The charts are consistent with the story. I used visuals that are easy to interpret, with the same color pattern and clear labels, but not overfitted with numbers. Each chart is added to focus on a specific area of expenditure and contribute meaningfully to the story. My goal was to design the visuals in a way that the key insights I provided in the analysis can be clearly seen.

But there are a few weaknesses too. Even though the visuals are appropriate, they lack variability, in my opinion. Four out of six charts are bar charts, which are fine, since they are formatted differently, but might seem like lazy work. It is mostly because of the data and the research question - the main focus is on distributions of expenses and comparison. That is where the bar chart is perfect. But to maintain reader engagement, I could have also used treemaps or line graphs, for example.

Also, while the story is consistent, some transitions could be smoother. Sometimes the analysis seems like a series of descriptions of visuals instead of the well-explained research and its insights. So the story can still be improved by adding smoother links between different sections of analysis.

Finally, the summary of the story in the end needs considerate corrections. It is too short and not explanatory, consisting of just a few key insights instead of an interesting and clear

conclusion on how Manchester City Council's expenditure changed between Q4 2024 - Q1 2025.

I have provided a clear analysis of Manchester City Council's expenditure. While the story is well-structured and has appropriate visuals that are easy on the eye, it also can be improved by adding smoother transitions from one insight to another and other types of visuals. Also, the final summary needs to contain a more comprehensive explanation of overall change in expenditure.

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